

Jeel Mawoud - Chapter 2: With the Attributes of the Promised Generation

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The Generation Promised Victory and Empowerment

Chapter Two: With the Attributes of the Promised Generation

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Translation Conventions

- Page markers as ## Page XX
- Quranic verses: English translation only, cited as (Quran, surah-name chapter:verse)
- Hadith: English translation only, with source reference and grade where known
- Key Arabic terms in parentheses with transliteration
- No Arabic script included — English-only translation
- Faithful sentence-by-sentence translation from the Arabic original

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Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — informed us in His Book that there are attributes and conditions that must be present in the group or generation that He — Glorified is He — will empower, support with His aid and strength, and grant victory over its enemies. And this is not conditional on a specific place or time; rather, the matter is open to everyone across time and place. What is required is simply fulfilling the qualifying conditions for entering into Allah's companionship (al-ma'iyah), protection (al-kifayah), and victory (al-nasr).

It Is Not Mere Theoretical Talk

And before the discussion moves on to the attributes of the promised generation, there is a matter worthy of attention: that the talk about the promised generation and what Allah can realize for it is not theoretical, hypothetical talk used to blacken pages, nor is it wishes or dreams that we dream and flee through from our bitter reality. No, by Allah; rather, they are realities that can occur, and faster than some might imagine, if we all strive to complete the required conditions and rise up to realize the attributes of the promised generation in ourselves and in those around us:

"Whoever thinks that Allah will not help him in this world and the Hereafter, let him extend a rope to the sky, then cut it, and let him see whether his plan will remove what enrages him."
(Quran, Al-Hajj 22:15)

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The history of our ummah tells us that there was a generation among the generations that actualized those conditions within itself, so Allah fulfilled His promise with it. That is the generation of the Companions — may Allah be pleased with them — who, before their Islam, were at the height of ignorance (jahiliyyah), division, and fragmentation. Then Islam came, and its light entered their hearts, and inner change took place, so their personalities were reformed anew, and they fulfilled what Allah required of them. Swift and noble fulfillment came from Him — Glorified is He — upon the earth for them, so they were able to destroy oppressive empires and within a few years become the foremost power in the world, and to carry humanity into a new, bright era.

This generation, before its Islam, was far farther from Allah than we are now; yet it changed what was within itself, fulfilled the conditions qualifying for victory (al-nasr) and empowerment (al-tamkin), dominated the earth, and produced great glory for Islam.

So the matter now is in our hands. We do not need huge preparations, or external assistance, or...; rather, we need to change what is within ourselves so that the promised generation may appear among us, leading the ummah to honour and sovereignty, just as happened with the first generation.

The Loss of Glory

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Because the promise of Allah is never broken: when a group of people actualized the attributes and conditions qualifying for victory — despite their lack of material means — Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — granted them victory and empowered them on earth; and when the later generations began gradually abandoning those attributes, there came abandonment (al-khizlan), loss, and a return once more to backwardness, so the status of the disbelievers rose again and the situation reached the misery and loss in which we now find ourselves.

Allah's Way with the Children of Israel

And indeed the promise of Allah and His way (sunnah) were fulfilled in both aspects upon the Children of Israel: when a generation among them fulfilled the conditions qualifying for entering into divine companionship (al-ma'iyah), there came from Him — Glorified is He — aid, support, and victory:

"And We caused the people who had been oppressed to inherit the eastern regions of the earth and the western ones, which We had blessed. And the good word of your Lord was fulfilled upon the Children of Israel because of what they had patiently endured. And We destroyed [all] that Pharaoh and his people were producing and what they used to erect." (Quran, Al-A'raf 7:137)

And time never ceased revolving until other people took the glory from us, and my people are no longer seen among the caravans, though their leaders lived for many years.

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This divine empowerment (al-tamkin) only occurred for the Children of Israel when they fulfilled what Allah required of them. So did they preserve it? The Quran tells us that after that they began deviation and gradual distancing from the state that had qualified them to enter

the circle of companionship (al-ma'iyyah) and divine favour. Arrogance (al-kibr), oppression (al-zulm), and even association (shirk) began to appear among them. So Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — granted them respite and pardoned them time after time, hoping they would return to their former covenant. But they persisted in their misguidance and insisted on their oppression and arrogance, so their painful punishment from Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — came:

"They have been put under humiliation wherever they are found, except by a rope [of protection] from Allah and a rope [of protection] from the people. And they have drawn upon themselves wrath from Allah, and poverty was struck upon them. That is because they disbelieved in the signs of Allah and killed the prophets without right. That is because they disobeyed and were transgressing." (Quran, Aal Imran 3:112)

Honour Is in Proportion to Uprightness

Thus, entering the circle of divine support (al-ta'yid) requires conditions, and remaining within it requires steadfastness (al-thabat) upon these conditions. The honour of servants with their Lord is according to their uprightness (al-istiqamah) and piety (al-taqwa), and the continuation of honour is through the continuation of uprightness.

Did He not say — exalted is He — to His beloved Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him:

"And if you follow their desires after what has come to you of knowledge, you will not have from Allah any protector and any intercessor." (Quran, Ar-Ra'd 13:37)

It is a heavenly law:

"And your Lord does wrong no one." (Quran, Al-Kahf 18:49)

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With the Attributes of the Generation of Change

From what has preceded it becomes clear to us that there must exist a generation in whom the attributes that qualify it to enter the circle of companionship (al-ma'iyyah), victory (al-nasr), and divine support (al-ta'yid) are realized. Yes, these attributes may be found in individuals here and there, but that alone is not enough; rather, there must exist a bonded generation (jeel mutarabit) upon which victory and empowerment descend.

As for the attributes of the generation of empowerment (al-tamkin), the Quran has spoken of them in many of its verses, so we must seek them out, reflect upon them, and extract from it what they indicate of attributes.

Here are some of these verses for you, dear reader:

1. Allah — exalted is He — said:

“Allah has promised those who have believed among you and done righteous deeds that He will surely grant them succession [in authority] upon the earth just as He granted it to those before them, and that He will surely establish for them [therein] their religion which He has preferred for them, and that He will surely substitute for them, after their fear, security, [for] they worship Me, not associating anything with Me. But whoever disbelieves after that — then those are the defiantly disobedient.” (Quran, An-Nur 24:55)

In this verse we find that Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — has promised a group of His believing servants succession (istikhlaf) and empowerment (al-tamkin), and linked this promise to worshipping Him and not associating partners with Him. Thus among the attributes of the promised generation are worship (al-‘ibadah) and complete sincerity (al-ikhlas) to Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He.

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2. Allah — exalted is He — said:

“O you who have believed, whoever of you should revert from his religion — Allah will bring forth [in place of them] a people He will love and who will love Him, [who will be] humble toward the believers, mighty against the disbelievers; they will strive in the path of Allah and will not fear the blame of a critic. That is the favor of Allah; He bestows it upon whom He wills. And Allah is all-Encompassing and Knowing. Your ally is none but Allah and [therefore] His Messenger and those who have believed — those who establish prayer and give zakah, and they bow [in worship]. And whoever is an ally of Allah and His Messenger and those who have believed — indeed, the party of Allah will be the predominant.” (Quran, Al-Ma’idah 5:54–56)

These verses speak of some attributes of the party of Allah (hizb Allah) whom He — exalted is He — honours with predominance and victory. These attributes are:

First: love of Allah (mahabbah).

Second: humility (tawadu’).

Third: continuous jihad (jihad).

Fourth: worship (al-‘ibadah).

Fifth: loyalty and brotherhood (al-muwalah wa al-ta’akhi).

3. Allah — exalted is He — said:

“And prepare against them whatever you are able of power and of steeds of war by which you may terrify the enemy of Allah and your enemy...” (Quran, Al-Anfal 8:60)

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This verse addresses the attribute of jihad in its broad sense, comprising exertion in material preparation in all its available forms and within the limits of ability.

4. Allah — exalted is He — said:

“And those who disbelieved said to their messengers, ‘We will surely drive you out of our land, or you must return to our religion.’ So their Lord inspired to them [the truth]: ‘We will surely destroy the wrongdoers. And We will surely cause you to dwell in the land after them. That is for whoever fears My station and fears My threat.’” (Quran, Ibrahim 14:13–14)

Here the verses focus on fear of Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — as a fundamental attribute of empowerment.

5. Allah — exalted is He — said:

“And We have already written in the book [of Psalms] after the [previous] mention that the land is inherited by My righteous servants. Indeed, in this is a message for a people devoted [to Allah].” (Quran, Al-Anbiya 21:105–106)

Through these verses we find that worship (al-‘ibadah) and righteousness (al-salah) must be among the attributes of the generation of empowerment.

6. Allah — exalted is He — said:

“And the good word of your Lord was fulfilled upon the Children of Israel because of what they had patiently endured.” (Quran, Al-Araf 7:137)

And He — exalted is He — said:

“And We made from among them leaders, guiding by Our command, when they were patient and [when] they were certain of Our signs.” (Quran, As-Sajdah 32:24)

In these verses we find patience (sabr) and steadfastness (thabat) on the truth among the most important attributes of the victorious group:

“That is from the news of the unseen which We reveal to you. You knew it not, neither you nor your people, before this. So be patient; indeed, the [best] outcome is for the righteous.” (Quran, Hud 11:49)

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7. Allah — exalted is He — said:

“So be steadfast as you are commanded, and those who turn in repentance with you, and do not transgress. Indeed, He is All-Seeing of what you do. And do not incline toward the wrongdoers, lest the Fire touch you, and you would not have any protectors besides Allah; then you would not be helped.” (Quran, Hud 11:112–113)

Here we find the divine face of the believing group in the necessity of being characterized by the attribute of moderation (al-wasatiyyah) and balance (al-i’tidal); for transgression (al-tughyan) represents extremism (al-tashaddud), and inclination (al-rukun) represents negligence (al-tafrīt) and laxity (al-tarkhis), while uprightness (al-istiqamah) lies between them; without it the believers depart from the circle of divine guardianship (al-wilayah) and support (al-nasr), as the verses have clarified.

As confirming this meaning, He — exalted is He — said:

"And thus We have made you a middle nation, that you may be witnesses over mankind and the Messenger be a witness over you." (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:143)

8. And in contrast to the verses that speak of the attributes of the promised generation of victory and empowerment, we find verses that speak of the causes of defeat and departure from the circle of companionship (al-ma'iyah) and divine support (al-ta'yid). From these verses one understands the necessity of abandoning these attributes for whoever desires victory and empowerment. Among them is His — exalted is He — saying:

"O you who have believed, what is [the matter] with you that, when you are told to go forth in the cause of Allah, you adhere heavily to the earth? Are you satisfied with the life of this world rather than the Hereafter? But what is the enjoyment of the life of this world compared to the Hereafter except a [very] little. If you do not go forth, He will punish you with a painful punishment and will replace you with another people, and you will not harm Him at all. And Allah is over all things competent." (Quran, At-Tawbah 9:38–39)

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Thus attachment to this world is among the most dangerous causes leading to departure from the circle of companionship (al-ma'iyah) and divine victory (al-nasr). Hence it is necessary that asceticism (zuhd) in this world and non-attachment to it be among the attributes of the promised generation.

The Ten Attributes

So if we wanted to gather the attributes indicated by the preceding verses, we would find them to be:

1. Sincerity to Allah (al-ikhlas lillah).
2. Love of Allah (mahabbah Allah).
3. Fear of Allah (khawf Allah).
4. Worship (al-'ibadah).
5. Humility (tawadu').
6. Asceticism toward the world (al-zuhd fi al-dunya).
7. Jihad in the path of Allah (al-jihad fi sabil Allah).
8. Patience and steadfastness (al-sabr wa al-thabat).
9. Loyalty and brotherhood (al-muwalah wa al-ta'akhi).

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The tenth attribute remains, one of great importance and that should be present in the generation of change — namely, the attribute of moderation (al-wasatiyyah) and balance (al-i'tidal). Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — demanded of His Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him, and those with him that they realize it while they were still in Mecca, being pursued and persecuted. He — exalted is He — said:

"So be steadfast as you are commanded, and those who turn in repentance with you, and do not transgress. Indeed, He is All-Seeing of what you do. And do not incline toward the wrongdoers, lest the Fire touch you, and you would not have any protectors besides Allah; then you would not be helped." (Quran, Hud 11:112–113)

For transgression represents extremism, inclination represents negligence and laxity, while uprightness lies between them; without it the believers depart from the circle of divine guardianship and support, as the verses have clarified.

Between Individualism and Collectivism

What is observed in the preceding attributes is that some of them have an individual character, meaning that they concern each individual separately and it is upon him to realize them in himself, such as sincerity to Allah, love of Him, and fear of Him. Some other attributes have a collective character, meaning that they cannot be realized except through the group of individuals, some with others, such as preparation and brotherhood. This is what the Quran emphasizes in its address to the believing group, and what we observe is that it addresses them in the plural form, considering that many of the principal attributes of the generation of empowerment cannot be realized except through the cooperation of individuals

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with one another, and their melting in a single crucible. Reflect with me on His — exalted is He — saying:

“Those who, if We give them authority in the land, establish prayer and give zakah and enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong. And to Allah belongs the outcome of [all] matters.” (Quran, Al-Hajj 22:41)

And His saying — exalted is He —:

“The believing men and believing women are allies of one another. They enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong and establish prayer and give zakah and obey Allah and His Messenger. Those — Allah will have mercy upon them. Indeed, Allah is Exalted in Might and Wise.” (Quran, At-Tawbah 9:71)

Can Other Attributes Be Added?

Before moving on to speak about these ten attributes in some detail, there is an observation worthy of drawing attention to: some of us may see that there are other attributes that can be added to these, whether individual such as knowledge (al-ilm) and reliance on Allah (al-tawakkul 'ala Allah), or collective such as discipline (al-inzibat), obedience (al-ta'ah), enjoining good (al-amr bil-ma'ruf), and forbidding evil (al-nahy 'an al-munkar).

Yes, there is no objection to that, especially since these attributes — as will be explained — are but fruits that issue from several axes. When these axes are realized in the promised generation, they will — by Allah's will — bear these ten attributes and others that may be added, in a natural and smooth manner.

This means that these attributes are not exhaustive; although they form the most important distinguishing traits of the promised generation.

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In the coming pages — with Allah's help — light will be shed on the ten attributes of the promised generation, with a presentation of models from the first generation in which these attributes were realized.

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First: Sincerity to Allah, Mighty and Exalted

(A Generation of Sincere Devotion)

Allah — exalted is He — said:

"Allah has promised those who have believed among you and done righteous deeds that He will surely grant them succession [in authority] upon the earth just as He granted it to those before them, and that He will surely establish for them [therein] their religion which He has preferred for them, and that He will surely substitute for them, after their fear, security, [for] they worship Me, not associating anything with Me. But whoever disbelieves after that — then those are the defiantly disobedient." (Quran, An-Nur 24:55)

The verse addresses the believers and gives them the glad tidings of the divine promise of succession (istikhlaf) and empowerment (al-tamkin) on earth, on the condition that they worship Him and do not associate anything with Him.

It is noteworthy that the verse mentions the word "anything" (shay'an), to exclude shirk from the narrow circle — the circle of manifest shirk — to the wide circle that includes all forms of shirk, whether in direction and intention or in seeking help.

Shirk of Intention and Purpose

Shirk of intention and purpose is that a person intend from his actions Allah's pleasure from one side, and from another side seek by those actions people's pleasure and love for him, and the raising of his status among them; or he intend by his actions Allah's pleasure and also the attainment of booty, prestige, or any worldly benefit.

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Thus everything that contradicts complete and absolute orientation to Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — is shirk.

On the authority of Abu Hurayrah, may Allah be pleased with him, who said: I heard the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, say:

"Allah — exalted is He — said: I am the One Who has no need of any partner. Whoever does a deed in which he associates with Me someone other than Me, I abandon him and his association."(1)

And on the authority of Shaddad ibn Aws, who said: I saw the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, weeping, so I said: What makes you weep, O Messenger of Allah? He said:

"I fear for my ummah the hidden shirk. They do not worship an idol, nor the sun, nor the moon, nor a stone, but they show off with their deeds."(2)

Shirk of Seeking Help

And just as we are required to devote our intention to Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — and that His pleasure alone be the purpose in all our deeds, we are also required to seek His help alone in performing any deed, for there is no might nor power except with Allah. When

a person seeks help from other than his Lord and thinks he will reach his goal without Him — Glorified is He — then he has associated partners with Him.

Among the hidden forms of seeking help from other than Allah:

- (1) Seeking help through the self and believing that what Allah has endowed it with of abilities is the servant's own property, which he may favour others with, or that he can use and rely on it whenever he wishes. So when he reaches his goal he rejoices in himself and looks at it with approval and admiration. This is self-admiration ('ujb), which is counted among the most dangerous types of shirk with Allah.

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Thus shirk with Allah includes everything that shares in directing the servant's deeds to Allah, and also includes everything by which the servant seeks help to perform those deeds.

Ibn Taymiyyah said: "Riyā' is from the gate of associating partners with the creation, and 'ujb is from the gate of associating partners with the self."

And he said: "The self-admiring person cannot realize 'You alone we ask for help,' just as the ostentatious person cannot realize 'You alone we worship.'"(1)

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The Danger of Hidden Shirk

As for the danger of hidden shirk, whether riyā' or 'ujb and what they lead to of delusion, arrogance (al-kibr), and hypocrisy (nifaq), it is great. The least of it is the nullification of deeds, for every deed mixed with riyā' or 'ujb is nullified and becomes scattered dust. He — exalted is He — said:

"O you who have believed, do not invalidate your charities with reminders [of it] or injury, like the one who spends his wealth to be seen by the people..." (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:264)

And alongside the nullification of deeds, 'ujb leads to Allah's anger and contempt. The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said:

"Whoever magnifies himself in his own soul and struts in his walk will meet Allah while He is angry with him."(2)

And he said:

"The one who repents awaits mercy, while the self-admiring person awaits wrath."(3)

And 'ujb also leads to abandonment (al-khizlan), deprivation of success (al-tawfiq), and exposure to trials. We have in the story of the Battle of Hunayn the clearest example:

"Already Allah has given you victory in many regions and [even] on the day of Hunayn, when your great number pleased you, but it did not avail you in any way; and the earth was confining for you with what broadened it; then you turned away, fleeing." (Quran, At-Tawbah 9:25)

Thus the matter is not only in devoting one's intention to Allah, but true help-seeking from Him — Glorified is He — is also necessary, and not viewing the deed or the self with joy, approval, and admiration.

From here our certainty grows in the necessity of the presence of the attribute of complete sincerity (al-ikhlas al-tamm) to Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — in intention and help-seeking among the children of the promised generation; otherwise there is no victory and no empowerment.

Manifestations of Sincerity

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When the servant proceeds on the path of sincerity to Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — this is such that it leaves effects and signs upon him which he feels inwardly and which those around him observe.

- Among these signs is that the servant will not wait behind his deed for the approval of his superiors, or for praise to be directed to him, or for titles to be conferred upon him, or for him to be preferred over his colleagues.
- Among them is that he will strive to hide his position and his work as much as possible, so he will not speak of it allusively or explicitly.
- Among them is that he will not seek to know people's opinion of his deeds; rather, he does the deed, exerts effort in forgetting it, concealing it, and not speaking of it.
- Among them also: that he fears for himself the trial of fame and spotlight, so he repels it from himself as much as possible.
- Among them: that work in the front ranks is equal to work in the rear ranks for him; indeed, his work in the rear will be dearer to him, because there he is not exposed to people's gaze or their praise.
- Among them: that praise and blame are equal to him, to the point that he repels people's praise for fear of its negative effects upon himself.
- Among them: that he is not distressed when his deed is attributed to someone else.
- Among them: that he helps others in their work and works for its success without anyone sensing his involvement.

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- Among them: that he has a secret of righteous deeds between himself and Allah that no one but He knows.
- Among them: that he will not feel distressed when the choice passes him by for undertaking a work in which he has more prior experience than others; rather, he assists the one chosen for it and offers him advice and experience.
- Among them: that he will not be concerned with people's pleasure or displeasure with him.
- Among them: that he will not speak about himself in a way that purifies it, nor will he often say "I... for me... I have..."
- Among them: that he will not boast to anyone over something Allah has favoured him with.
- Among them: that he will not try to display all his capabilities and knowledge before others.

- Among them: that he will not look for gain from behind his work, nor will he exploit his position to achieve worldly benefits for himself or his relatives and friends.
- Among them: not reminding others of favours, and not recalling them to them in any form.
- Among them: that he increases in seeking forgiveness (istighfar) after his righteous deeds.
- Among them: that he strives against his soul and does not surrender to thoughts of self-admiration; rather, he treats them and gives them the antidote that restores balance and places it in the mould of servitude (al-ubudiyyah).

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- Among them also: that he does not see himself as sincere; rather, he always has a bad opinion of himself, accuses it of hypocrisy and... and... and many other things that indicate complete sincerity to Allah — Mighty and Exalted is He — in intention and help-seeking.

The First Generation and Sincerity

Whoever examines and studies the biography of the Companions — may Allah be pleased with them —

Footnotes

The original footnote numbering restarts with each page; the page reference below matches the in-text marker.

- **(1)** (p. 37): Narrated by Muslim; grade: sahih (as stated in source).
 - **(2)** (p. 37): Narrated by Ibn Majah and al-Hakim; grade not specified in source.
 - **(1)** (p. 38): Al-'Ubbah li-'Amr ibn Musa al-Hafiz, vol. 11, quoting from Majmu' al-Fatawa of Ibn Taymiyyah, 10/277.
 - **(2)** (p. 39): Sahih. Narrated by Imam Ahmad in his Musnad, and al-Bukhari in Al-Adab al-Mufrad on the authority of Ibn 'Umar, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami', no. 6157.
 - **(3)** (p. 39): Cited by al-Bayhaqi in Shu'ab al-Iman, no. 7245; grade not specified in source.
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And they are the generation in whom Allah's promise of succession (istikhlāf) and enablement (tamkīn) was fulfilled, and one finds that the manifestations of the attribute of sincerity (al-ikhlas) had clearly appeared in them.

Look, for example, at their keenness to hide their deeds, which is shown in this report:

From Abū Mūsā al-Ash'arī, may Allah be pleased with him, who said: We went out with the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, on a military expedition, and we were six persons between whom was a camel we would take turns riding. He said: So our feet became sore; my feet became sore, and my toenails fell off, so we used to wrap pieces of cloth around our feet. It was called the Expedition of Dhāt al-Riqā' because we wrapped pieces of

cloth around our feet. Abū Buraydah said: Abū Mūsā narrated this hadith, then he disliked that, as if he disliked that anything of his deed be disclosed.(1)

(1) Narrated by Muslim.

And this is ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, may Allah be pleased with him, entering the mosque and seeing Mu‘ādh ibn Jabal, may Allah be pleased with him, weeping at the grave of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him. He said: What makes you weep? He said: I heard the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, say: “The slightest showing off (al-riyā’) is shirk. Indeed Allah loves the pious ones who are hidden (al-atqiyā’ al-akhfiyā’): when they are absent they are not missed, and when they are present they are not recognized. Their hearts are lamps of guidance; they are saved from every dark calamity.”(1)

(1) Narrated by al-Ṭabarānī and al-Ḥākim, and the wording is his, and he said: Ṣaḥīḥ al-isnād.

They were extremely cautious with themselves, and they stood on guard before every thought of self-admiration (‘ujb). ‘Urwah said: I saw ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, may Allah be pleased with him, with a waterskin of water on his shoulder, so I said: O Commander of the Believers, this is not fitting for you. He said: When the delegations came to me with hearing and obedience, pride entered my soul, so I wanted to break it, and he went with the waterskin to the quarters of an Ansārī woman and poured it into her vessel...

And this is Abū Bakr al-Ṣiddīq, may Allah be pleased with him, sending a letter to Khālīd ibn al-Walīd — may Allah be pleased with him — after his victories in Iraq, in which he said to him: May your intention and high standing be humbled, and Allah will complete the orphan for you; and let no self-admiration enter you, for then you will lose and be forsaken; and beware of showing off with a deed, for Allah has the favour, and He is the Master of recompense.(2)

(2) Al-Akhfiyā’ by Walīd Sa‘īd al-Ḥakīm, 129 — Dār al-Andalus al-Khaḍrā’ — Jeddah — quoted from Tārīkh al-Ṭabarī 3/385.

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...and this is Abū ‘Ubaydah ibn al-Jarrāḥ, may Allah be pleased with him, leading a people in prayer. When he finished, he said: Satan was at my side until I saw that I had a virtue over the one behind me; I will never lead prayer again.(3)

(3) Al-Zuhd by Ibn al-Mubārak, no. 834 (p. 287).

...and they would push away praise and not surrender to it. Thus ‘Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib, may Allah be pleased with him, when he was praised, would say: O Allah, forgive me for what they do not know, and do not take me to task for what they say, and make me better than what they think.

And a man once said to Ibn ‘Umar, may Allah be pleased with them both: O best of people, and son of the best of people. He said: I am not the best of people, nor the son of the best of people, but I am a servant from among Allah’s servants; I hope in Allah and I fear Him. By Allah, you will not stop following a man until you destroy him.

As for their fear for themselves of hypocrisy, here is this report for you:

Ibn Abī Mulaykah said: I met thirty of the companions of the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, every one of whom feared hypocrisy for himself.

And ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, may Allah be pleased with him, used to say to Ḥudhayfah, may Allah be pleased with him: I adjure you by Allah, did the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings

be upon him, name me to you — meaning among the hypocrites? He would say: No, and I will not declare anyone righteous after you.(4)

(4) Al-Dā' wa al-Dawā' by Ibn al-Qayyim, 83 — Dār Ibn Kathīr — Damascus.

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Second: The dominance of the love of Allah in the heart

(A generation that loves Allah, exalted and majestic)

Allah, exalted, says: "O you who have believed, whoever of you should revert from his religion, Allah will bring forth a people whom He will love and who will love Him, humble toward the believers, mighty against the disbelievers, striving in the cause of Allah and not fearing the blame of a critic. That is the favour of Allah; He gives it to whom He wills. And Allah is all-Encompassing and Knowing. Your ally is none but Allah and His Messenger and those who have believed — those who establish prayer and give zakāh, and they bow. And whoever is an ally of Allah and His Messenger and those who have believed — indeed, the party of Allah will be the predominant." (Quran, Al-Mā'idah 5:54-56).

These verses speak of the generation and the group whom Allah, exalted and majestic, loves and is pleased with, and for whom He writes victory over their enemies.

This group has several attributes that the previous verses have clarified, and the first of these attributes is their love of Allah, exalted and majestic: "whom He will love and who will love Him."

If you say: But all Muslims love Allah, exalted and majestic, so what is the point of this attribute?

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...Yes, there is love of Allah in hearts, but the love that He — exalted is He — wants from the promised generation is a love that overwhelms the heart and dominates it, until Allah becomes more beloved to him than everything: "And those who believe are stronger in love for Allah." (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:165).

This true love has signs by which it is known... among them:

1. Obedience to the beloved and working for His pleasure

The servant who loves Allah hastens and rushes to attain His pleasure. Look at Moses, peace be upon him, as he leaves the Children of Israel behind him to meet his Lord, saying: "And I hastened to You, my Lord, that You might be pleased." (Quran, Tā Hā 20:84).

And the true lover continues to be eager to please his Lord, even if he expends in that cause all that he owns: "And among the people is he who sells himself, seeking the pleasure of Allah." (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:207).

2. Swiftiness in turning back to Allah

Among the signs of true love is the servant's hastening to repentance, seeking forgiveness, apologising, pouring out tears, and seeking to appease his Master when he falls into a sin or falls short in performing a duty, due to his constant fear of his Lord's anger against him. Look at Muḥammad, peace and blessings be upon him, as he privately converses with his Lord and seeks to please Him after what befell him at al-Ṭā'if of rejection and aversion, and his fear

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...that the cause of that lay with himself. He said, peace and blessings be upon him: "...If You are not angry with me, I do not care; rather, Your well-being is more expansive for me... I seek refuge in the light of Your face, by which the darknesses are illuminated and by which the affairs of this world and the Hereafter are set right, that Your wrath should descend upon me or Your displeasure befall me. Yours is the reproach until You are pleased, and there is no power and no strength except with You..."(1)

(1) Sunan al-Tirmidhī; also narrated by al-Ḥākim and others.

3. Gratitude for His gifts

The true lover receives the guidance and gifts of his Lord with joy, happiness, and gratitude, and he attributes to Him every favour and good that comes to him. We find him ever-remembering His blessings, praising and thanking Him for them.

4. Patience in tribulations and contentment with the decree

For the true lover of Allah bears the tribulation his Lord sends to him and is content with His decree, for he knows that He does not intend anything but good for him, and that He only tried him to purify him and draw him nearer to Him: "And those who are patient, seeking the countenance of their Lord." (Quran, Ar-Ra'd 13:22).

5. Abundant private devotion (munājāh)

Among the signs of true love of Allah is love of solitude with Him, abundant private conversation with Him and praise of Him, and laying oneself bare before Him... And since private devotion is specific to the beloved alone, the lover always waits until sounds quiet down, eyes fall asleep, and the place becomes empty, then he rushes to his Lord and finds intimacy with Him. How beautiful are the moments of intimacy in the vastness of prayer, and especially in prostration... For that reason the best prayer after the obligatory prayer was the night prayer (qiyām al-layl), when the atmosphere is prepared for contact... at that time our Lord descends to the lowest heaven in a manner befitting His glory and perfection.

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So how can one who claims to love Allah turn away from meeting his Beloved, or leave Him and sleep?

Al-Fuḍayl ibn 'Iyād took al-Ḥusayn ibn Ziyād by the hand and said: O Ḥusayn, Allah, exalted, descends every night to the lowest heaven, and the Lord says: "The one who claims to love Me has lied; when night covers him he sleeps away from Me... Does not every lover love the solitude of his beloved? Here I am, looking upon My beloved ones when night covers them; I place Myself between their eyes, so they converse with Me in direct vision and speak with Me in present encounter. Tomorrow I will satisfy the eyes of My beloved ones in My Garden."(1)

(1) Rahbān al-Layl by Sayyid al-'Afānī, 1/408.

6. Love of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him

Among the signs of true love is love of what He, exalted, loves, and the most beloved to Allah, exalted and majestic, is His Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him. And the practical translation of love of Allah and His Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him, is obedience to him in what he brought from his Lord: "Say, [O Muḥammad], 'If you should love Allah, then follow me, Allah will love you.'" (Quran, Āl 'Imrān 3:31).

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The love of Allah intensified in the hearts of the Ṣaḥābah, so some of them went to the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, to inform him of that, saying to him: O Messenger of Allah, by Allah we love our Lord. So Allah, exalted and majestic, revealed His saying: "Say, [O Muḥammad], 'If you should love Allah, then follow me, Allah will love you.'"(2)

(2) Al-Jāmi' li-Aḥkām al-Qur'ān al-'Aẓīm by al-Qurṭubī, 4/40 — Dār al-Kutub al-'Ilmiyyah.

And al-Ḥāfiẓ Ibn Kathīr comments on this verse, saying: This verse is decisive against everyone who claims love of Allah while not following the Muḥammadan way, for he is a liar in his claim until he follows the Muḥammadan law and the prophetic religion in all his sayings and deeds. Al-Ḥasan said: A people claimed that they loved Allah, so Allah tested them with this verse.(3)

(3) Tafsīr al-Qur'ān al-'Aẓīm by al-Ḥāfiẓ Ibn Kathīr, 1/314 — Maktabat al-'Ubaykān.

7. Among the signs of true love is that Allah and His Messenger become more beloved to him than all else.

So every other love, whether for a wife, children, parents, or mothers, should be subordinate to this love; it should not compete with it or oppose it. This becomes clear when the love of Allah and His Messenger and what they require conflicts with the love of something else, as Allah, exalted, says: "Say, 'If your fathers, your sons, your brothers, your wives, your clans, the wealth you have gained, a trade you fear may decline, and dwellings you love are dearer to you than Allah and His Messenger and striving in His cause, then wait until Allah brings about His command.'" (Quran, At-Tawbah 9:24).

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8. Among the signs of true love is love for Allah's sake and hatred for Allah's sake.

The true lover in his claim loves what his Master loves and hates what He hates.

The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "The strongest handhold of faith is loyalty for Allah's sake, enmity for Allah's sake, love for Allah's sake, and hatred for Allah's sake."(2)

(2) Ṣaḥīḥ; narrated by al-Ṭabarānī from Ibn 'Abbās, and authenticated by al-Albānī in Ṣaḥīḥ al-Jāmi', no. 2539.

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That means this servant loves the Muslims and hates the disbelievers, and he loves the Muslim who adheres to Allah's commands more than the one who is negligent in his regard, and he loves the strong believer more than the weak believer, and he loves the people of the mosques who preserve the Friday and congregational prayers and follow the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, more than those who do not preserve that; and he loves the people of jihād who proceed on the correct path to establish the religion of Allah on earth more than others who sit back from jihād or deviate from its path; and he loves in those who remain behind their adherence to the other commands more than other Muslims who are astray; and so on.

9. Among them is love of the Qur'an.

Whoever loves Allah with a true love will naturally love His speech, delight in it, frequently recite it, listen to it, and understand its intended meaning.

Ibn Mas'ūd, may Allah be pleased with him, said: Let none of you be asked about himself except concerning the Qur'an. Whoever loves the Qur'an, then he loves Allah and His Messenger.(1)

(1) Ikhtiyār al-Awlā fī Sharḥ Ḥadīth Ikhtishām al-Malā' al-A'lā by Ibn Rajab.

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10. Abundant remembrance of Him

Among the signs of love of Allah is abundant remembrance of Him. For the lover abundantly mentions his beloved; therefore you see his tongue always moist with the remembrance of Allah, for it is to his heart like water is to a fish.

The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "The likeness of the one who remembers his Lord and the one who does not remember his Lord is like the living and the dead."(2)

(2) Narrated by al-Bukhārī.

11. Calling to Allah

Among the signs of love of Allah is calling people to Allah, endearing them to Him, and guiding them to Him. Abū al-Dardā' said: When Allah sent Adam down to earth, He said to him: O Adam, love Me and make Me beloved to My creatures... The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "The best of my ummah are those who call to Allah and make His servants beloved to Him."(3)

(3) Narrated by Ibn al-Najjār from Abū Hurayrah, mursal — see Kanz al-'Ummāl, 44069.

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12. Among them is anger for Allah's sake and protective jealousy for Him when His sacred limits are violated, His law is neglected, and His Book is cast aside.

13. Among them is love of jihād and martyrdom in the cause of Allah.

For jihād in the cause of Allah is expending effort and capacity for the sake of Allah's pleasure, exalted and majestic; as for martyrdom, it counts as the greatest proof that love of Him, exalted, is more beloved to the servant than everything.

The Ṣaḥābah and their love of Allah:

The hearts of the Ṣaḥābah were filled with the love of Allah, and the effects of that love appeared in their conduct, and they became clear when that love conflicted with other loves.

This love conflicted with the love of fathers, sons, and brothers at the Battle of Badr — so what happened?

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Abū 'Ubaydah, may Allah be pleased with him, killed his polytheist father when he met him in battle; and Abū Bakr al-Ṣiddīq, may Allah be pleased with him, was about to kill his son 'Abd al-Raḥmān; and Muṣ'ab ibn 'Umayr, may Allah be pleased with him, killed his brother 'Ubayd ibn 'Umayr; and 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, may Allah be pleased with him, killed a relative of his...

And concerning them was revealed His saying, exalted: "You will not find a people who believe in Allah and the Last Day having affection for those who oppose Allah and His Messenger, even if they were their fathers or their sons or their brothers or their kindred. Those — He

has decreed faith within their hearts and supported them with a spirit from Him. And He will admit them to gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding eternally therein. Allah is pleased with them, and they are pleased with Him. Those are the party of Allah. Unquestionably, the party of Allah — they are the successful.” (Quran, Al-Mujādilah 58:22).

...And the dominance of the love of Allah in the hearts of the Ṣaḥābah became clear at the Hijrah from Makkah to Madīnah, for the Emigrants left their wealth, homes, and emigrated fleeing with their religion and in obedience to the commands of their Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him. All of that would not have happened had not the love of Allah, exalted and majestic, dominated their hearts.

From al-Zubayr, may Allah be pleased with him, who said: The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, was sitting at Qubā’ with a group, when Muṣ’ab ibn ‘Umayr, may Allah be pleased with him, stood up. He was wearing a cloak that barely covered him, and he lowered his gaze before the people. He came and gave salām, and they returned it. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, spoke well of him and praised him, then said: “I saw this one at his father’s house in Makkah being honoured and favoured, and there was no youth among the youths of Quraysh like him; then he left all that seeking Allah’s pleasure and support of His Messenger.”(1)

(1) Narrated by al-Ḥākim... see Ḥayāt al-Ṣaḥābah, 3/120.

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Love of the Messenger:

As for their love of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, the examples are many...

Al-Ṭabarānī narrated from ‘Urwah ibn al-Zubayr that the polytheists who killed Khubayb ibn ‘Adī, may Allah be pleased with him, called out to him before killing him while he was crucified: Would you love for Muḥammad to be in your place? He said: No, by Allah the Great! I would not love that he be ransomed for me by a thorn pricking his foot.

As for their swiftness in rushing to jihād in the cause of Allah, look at what Ḥanzalah, may Allah be pleased with him, did. When he was martyred at Uḥud, the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: “Indeed your companion Ḥanzalah is being washed by the angels; ask his family what was the matter with him.” So his wife was asked, and she said: He went out in a state of major ritual impurity when he heard the caller. The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, said: “That is why the angels washed him.”(2)

(2) Narrated by Abū Nu‘aym in al-Ḥilyah.

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As for their love of martyrdom, do not ask about it, for they used to race to it with a wondrous competition. Thus ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, may Allah be pleased with him, said to his brother on the day of Uḥud: Take my shield, O my brother. He said: I desire martyrdom as you do, so they both left their shields.(3)

(3) Ḥayāt al-Ṣaḥābah, 1/32.

And this is ‘Abd Allāh ibn Jaḥsh, may Allah be pleased with him, supplicating Allah before the Battle of Uḥud, saying: O Allah, I adjure You to let me meet the enemy tomorrow, let them kill me, then rip open my belly, cut off my nose and ear, and when You ask me why, I will say: For You.(4)

(4) Ḥayāt al-Ṣaḥābah, 1/389.

As for Mu'adh ibn Jabal, may Allah be pleased with him, there is something amazing in his love for his Lord. When the throes of death intensified upon him after he was afflicted by the plague, whenever he regained consciousness he would open his collar and say: Choke me with Your choking, for by Your might You know that my heart loves You.(5)

(5) Al-Raqā'iq wa al-Bukā' by Ibn Qudāmah, 252; and see Ṭabaqāt Ibn Sa'd.

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Third: Intense fear of Allah, exalted and majestic

(A generation humble, fearing Allah)

Allah, exalted, says: "And their Lord had inspired them: We will surely destroy the wrongdoers, and We will surely settle you in the earth after them. That is for whoever fears My station and fears My threat." (Quran, Ibrāhīm 14:13-14).

And Allah, exalted, says: "Indeed, the earth belongs to Allah; He causes to inherit it whom He wills of His servants. And the outcome is for the righteous." (Quran, Al-A'rāf 7:128).

And Allah, exalted, says, addressing His Messenger: "That is from the news of the unseen which We reveal to you. You knew it not, neither you nor your people, before this. So be patient; indeed, the outcome is for the righteous." (Quran, Hūd 11:49).

Through these verses it becomes clear to us that fear of Allah should fill the hearts of the sons of the generation promised victory and enablement... a fear aroused by veneration, magnification, and awe of Allah, exalted and majestic; and aroused likewise by the feeling of falling short in fulfilling the rights of servitude... and fear of the consequences of sins from which no human can escape... and of exposure to an evil end, the stupor of death, the reckoning of the grave, the terrors of the Day of Resurrection, of being presented before Allah and exposed to reckoning, of the scales of good deeds not tipping in one's favour, of not being permitted to cross the Ṣirāṭ...

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There is a great difference between a passing fear that stirs the emotions, sends forth tears, and then passes on its way, and a constant fear that fills the heart and keeps it always in a state of remembrance and alertness.

Indeed the fear required to be present in the hearts of the sons of the generation of enablement is the fear that drives to action, produces taqwā, caution, and wara' in all words and deeds, so that its possessor is careful in his speech and leaves much of the permissible out of fear of falling into the forbidden.

What is required is a fear that drives its possessor to magnify the symbols of Allah: "That is so, and whoever honours the symbols of Allah — indeed, it is from the piety of hearts." (Quran, Al-Ḥajj 22:32). And it makes him hasten toward good deeds: "Indeed, those who are apprehensive from fear of their Lord, and those who believe in the signs of their Lord, and those who do not associate anything with their Lord, and those who give what they give while their hearts are fearful because they will be returning to their Lord — it is those who hasten to good deeds, and they are foremost in them." (Quran, Al-Mu'minūn 23:57-61).

That means fear of Allah plays a major role in the servant's steadfastness on the straight path, and from it enters into the circle of divine wilayah, support, and protective care: "If you are patient and fear Allah, their plotting will not harm you at all." (Quran, Āl 'Imrān 3:120).

Models of the fear of the Ṣaḥābah:

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When we examine this attribute in the generation of the Ṣaḥābah, we find that it had dominated them intensely, and its effects appeared in their lives and conduct. Thus Abū Bakr al-Ṣiddīq, may Allah be pleased with him — and he is the best of the ummah after the prophets and after the Messenger, peace and blessings be upon him — said: Would that I were a tree that is eaten and then digested. And it was mentioned of him that he would hold his tongue and say: This is what brought me to my end; and he wept much and said: Weep, and if you cannot weep, then make yourself weep.(1)

(1) Al-Dā' wa al-Dawā' by Ibn al-Qayyim, 80–84.

And this is 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, may Allah be pleased with him, saying at his death: By Allah, if I had all the gold on earth I would ransom myself with it from the punishment of Allah, exalted and majestic, before seeing it... And his last words before death were: Woe to me, and woe to my mother, if Allah does not forgive me.

And this is 'Uthmān, may Allah be pleased with him, saying: If I were between Paradise and the Fire, not knowing to which of them I am commanded, I would prefer to be ashes before knowing to which of them I will go.

Abū 'Ubaydah al-Jarrāḥ, may Allah be pleased with him, said: I wish I were a sheep, slaughtered by my family, who eat my flesh and drink my broth.

And 'Abd Allāh ibn 'Abbās's lower eyelids were like worn-out water-skins from tears.

And this is Abū Dharr saying: Would that I were a tree that is digested; I wish I had not been created.(2)

(2) Ḥayāt al-Ṣaḥābah, 2/372–373.

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A man said in the presence of 'Abd Allāh ibn Mas'ūd, may Allah be pleased with him: I would not love to be among the People of the Right; to be among the Near Ones is more beloved to me. 'Abd Allāh said: But here is a man who wished he had died and not been resurrected... meaning himself.

And Shaddād ibn Aws al-Anṣārī, may Allah be pleased with him, when he entered his bed would toss upon it, sleep not coming to him, so he would say: O Allah, the Fire has taken my sleep from me; then he would pray until morning.

And this is Umm al-Mu'minīn 'Ā'ishah, may Allah be pleased with her, saying: By Allah, I wish I were a tree; by Allah I wish I were a pebble; by Allah I wish Allah had not created me at all.(2)

And Ibn 'Abbās, may Allah be pleased with them both, entered upon her while she was dying and praised her, so she said: Leave me alone; by the One in whose hand is my soul, I wish I were forgotten and forgotten.(3)

(2) Al-Khawf min Allah Ta'ālā by Muḥammad Shawqān al-Ramlī, 80 — Dār Ibn 'Affān — Egypt.

(3) Al-Khawf min Allah Ta'ālā by Muḥammad Shawqān al-Ramlī, 80 — Dār Ibn 'Affān — Egypt.

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Fourth: A worshipping generation

Allah, exalted, says: “And We had already written in the Psalms after the mention that the earth shall be inherited by My righteous servants. Indeed, in this is a notification for a worshipping people.” (Quran, Al-Anbiyā’ 21:105–106).

The generation of enablement is a generation that worships Allah, exalted and majestic... abundant in remembrance, abundant in obedience... a generation known to the angels, and the mosques bear witness that it is among their caretakers and pillars.

...it rises early for prayer, and preserves the Sunnah prayers... it does not miss the night prayer no matter how tired it is.

...it has devotional practices it preserves of supererogatory prayers, and likewise the adhkār and recitation of the Qur’an.

...its delight is in prayer... it prolongs bowing and prostration, and increases in private converse with its Lord.

...abundant in spending... abundant in fasting... abundant in supplication.

...its concern for people and its call to them do not distract it from concern for itself, so it always preserves its balance, and its increase in faith.

Thus were the companions of Muḥammad, peace and blessings be upon him:

‘Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib, may Allah be pleased with him, describes the Ṣaḥābah, saying: I saw the companions of Muḥammad, peace and blessings be upon him, and I have not seen today anything resembling them. They would rise in the morning dishevelled and dusty, with marks between their eyes like the knees of goats,

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having spent the night to Allah in prostration and standing, reciting the Book of Allah, moving between their foreheads and their feet; when morning came they remembered Allah and swayed as a tree sways on a windy day, and their eyes flowed until their clothes were soaked...(1)

(1) Ṣalāḥ al-Ummah fī ‘ulu al-Himmah by Sayyid al-‘Afānī, 4/195 — Mu’assasat al-Risālah — Beirut.

The Ṣaḥābah, may Allah be pleased with them, were intensely keen on worship and especially on the congregational prayer in the mosque. Ibn Mas‘ūd, may Allah be pleased with him, said: “Whoever is pleased to meet Allah tomorrow as a Muslim, let him guard these prayers where the call is made for them, for Allah, exalted, has prescribed for your Prophet — peace and blessings be upon him — the Sunnahs of guidance, and indeed they are from the Sunnahs of guidance. If you were to pray in your houses as this one who stays behind prays in his house, you would abandon the Sunnah of your Prophet; and if you abandon the Sunnah of your Prophet you will go astray. There is no man who purifies himself well, then goes to one of these mosques, except that Allah records for him a good deed for every step he takes, raises him a degree by it, and erases from him a sin. We used to see that no one stayed away from them except a known hypocrite, and a man would be brought, supported between two men, until he stood in the row.”

And ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Umar, may Allah be pleased with them both, said: We used to consider a man suspect if we missed him at Fajr and ‘Ishā’.(2)

(2) Ḥayāt al-Ṣaḥābah, 3/39–40.

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Along with their intense keenness on the congregational prayer, they were also keen on the night prayer, and they used to treat it as the source of their intimacy and happiness, and neither fatigue nor travel would divert them from it.

So they were as described: monks by night, knights by day...

They spent their nights in obedience to their Lord, with recitation, supplication, and asking; their eyes flowed with a flood of tears like the pouring rain. At night they were monks, and when they strove against their enemy they were among the bravest of heroes, and when the banner of excellence appeared you would see them with righteous deeds.

...Hind, the wife of Abū Sufyān, may Allah be pleased with him, came to her husband the morning of the Conquest of Makkah and said: I want to pledge allegiance to Muḥammad, peace and blessings be upon him. Abū Sufyah said: I have seen you disbelieving. She said: Yes, by Allah, by Allah I have not seen Allah, exalted, worshipped with His rightful worship in this mosque before tonight; and by Allah, they did not spend the night except praying, standing, bowing, and prostrating.(1)

(1) Rahbān al-Layl by Sayyid al-'Afānī, 1/310.

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Fifth: Humility (al-tawāḍu')

(A humble generation)

Among the most important attributes that should be found in the generation promised victory and enablement is humility, which is emphasised by what came in His saying, exalted: "O you who have believed, whoever of you should revert from his religion, Allah will bring forth a people whom He will love and who will love Him, humble toward the believers, mighty against the disbelievers." (Quran, Al-Mā'idah 5:54).

For humility toward the believers and lowering the wing for them indicates the humility of its possessor.

The reality of humility is that a person sees himself as small... It is a state of the heart that the servant lives, and its effects appear in his conduct and dealings with his Lord, with himself, and with people.

With Allah:

The servant's humility in his relationship with his Lord stems from his perception of his reality and origin: that he is a created being, powerless, weak, ignorant... His origin is dust, and despicable water... It stems likewise from his sensing the greatness of his Lord, His majesty, His perfection, and the immensity of His favour upon him.

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This inner state should be translated by the servant into an image of submission, humbleness, and submissiveness to Allah, exalted and majestic, showing his utter poverty and need of Him, and that no matter what he is given of forms of health, strength, beauty, or wealth, he remains as he is: a humbled servant of a glorious Lord, and these things do not change his reality in the slightest.

With oneself:

The reality of humility with oneself is that a person sees it as small, views it with an eye of deficiency, and always places it in a station lower than it should be. Sufficient for you in that is what Moses — peace be upon him — did when he saw himself as small and considered it too great a burden to bear the message alone, so he asked his Lord to let his brother Hārūn — peace be upon him — help him carry it: “And my brother Hārūn is more fluent than me in tongue, so send him with me as a helper to confirm me, for I fear they will deny me.” (Quran, Al-Qaṣaṣ 28:34). Although the reality shows that he — peace be upon him — carried it in the best way.

Among the forms of a person’s humility is not putting himself forward to undertake something, and likewise seeing himself as unworthy of the work proposed to him.

Among them also is that he walks upon the earth humbly, not swaggering or strutting.

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With people:

A person’s humility with people stems from his view of them as better than him no matter what his deeds or rank may be; he always looks at the positive side of everyone he deals with and senses their superiority over him.

That appears in his conduct with them... so he does not disdain serving his family, he lowers his wing for the believers, he responds to the call of the poor and weak, he often sits with the needy, and he hastens to fulfil the needs of people.

The humility of the Ṣaḥābah:

This attribute clearly appeared and its effects were plainly visible in the generation of the Ṣaḥābah, may Allah be pleased with them. Look at Abū Bakr, may Allah be pleased with him: he continued milking sheep for his neighbour after assuming the caliphate, and he said to them when they thought he would not continue: By my life, I will milk them for you; I hope that what I have entered into will not change me from a character I used to be upon. So he continued milking for them.(1)

(1) Siyar al-Salaf al-Ṣāliḥ by al-Aṣbahānī, 1/83 — Dār al-Hudā — Riyadh.

And in his first sermon after assuming the caliphate he said to the people: I have been placed in authority over you, and I am not the best of you — despite the fact that he, may Allah be pleased with him, was the best of all people after the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him — but it was his self-deprecation.

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And this is ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, may Allah be pleased with him, entering Jerusalem as a conqueror: what was his state?

Between him and the servant boy who was with him there was a turn-taking. When they drew near to Syria it was the boy’s turn to ride, so the boy rode, and ‘Umar took the camel’s reins. Water met him on the road, so ‘Umar began wading through it, with his sandal under his left armpit, holding the camel’s reins. Abū ‘Ubaydah al-Jarrāḥ, may Allah be pleased with him, came out — and he was the governor over Syria — and said: O Commander of the Believers, the notables of Syria are coming out to you, so it is not proper that they see you in this state. ‘Umar said: It was only Islam that honoured us, so we do not care for the disparagement of people.(2)

(2) Tanbīh al-Ghāfilīn, 141 — Mu’assasat al-Tārīkh al-‘Arabī — Beirut.

And one day he passed by a woman who was mashing dates, and he said: This is not how dates are mashed; then he took the pestle and said: Like this.(3)

(3) Ṣalāḥ al-Ummah fī ‘ulu al-Himmah, 5/433.

And at his death — may Allah be pleased with him — he said to his son ‘Abd Allāh, may Allah be pleased with him: Put my face on the ground, O my son, perhaps Allah will have mercy on me... He said: So he rubbed his cheeks in the dust.(4)

(4) Al-Zuhd by Ibn al-Mubārak, 147.

And ‘Uthmān ibn ‘Affān, may Allah be pleased with him, was seen riding a mule, with his servant Na‘īl walking behind him while he was caliph, and he was also seen sleeping in the mosque wrapped in a cloak with no one around him while he was the Commander of the Believers.(5)

(5) Al-Zuhd by Imam Aḥmad, 127.

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And when ‘Umar appointed Abū Hurayrah governor of Bahrain, he entered it riding a donkey, and he began saying: Make way for the governor, make way for the governor.(6)

(6) Tanbīh al-Ghāfilīn, 142.

And ‘Abd al-Raḥmān ibn ‘Awf, may Allah be pleased with him, could not be distinguished from among his servants because of his humility in dress.(7)

(7) Al-Tawāḍu‘ wa al-Khumūl by Ibn Abī al-Dunyā, 170.

And Salmān al-Fārisī, may Allah be pleased with him, was the governor of al-Madā’in. A man of its notables had bought something, and he thought Salmān was a porter, so he said: Come and carry this. Salmān carried it, and the people began coming to meet him, saying: May Allah set right the governor, we will carry it from you. But he refused to hand it over to them. The man said to himself: Woe to you, I did not mock anyone but the governor. So he began apologising to him and saying: I did not recognise you, may Allah set you right. Salmān said: Go, and take it to his house, then he said: I will never mock anyone again.(1)

(1) Tanbīh al-Ghāfilīn, 142.

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Sixthly: Asceticism in the World (al-zuhd fī al-dunyā)

An Ascetic Generation (jeel zāhid)

The generation of change is an ascetic generation in the world, in the true meaning of asceticism (al-zuhd) — namely, turning desire away from the world and shunning it, as he, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, said: “What have I to do with the world!” (1)

How could the generation promised victory and empowerment be otherwise, when love of the world and desire for it are among the most important obstacles that stand between the servant and entering the sphere of divine guardianship (al-wilāyah al-ilāhiyyah). And the ummah was only afflicted with what afflicted it of weakness and humiliation because of its love for the world and its desire for it, and its preferring it over the Hereafter.

Our Messenger, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, foretold this, so he said: “The nations will soon call one another against you, just as diners call one another to their dish.”

It was said: "O Messenger of Allah, will it be because of our small number that day?" He said: "No, rather you will be many, but you will be like foam, like the foam of a torrent. Allah will place weakness in your hearts and remove fear of you from the hearts of your enemies — because of your love for this world and your hatred of death." (2)

It is therefore necessary that this attribute be present in the promised generation, and that love of the world depart from the hearts of its children. Its motto in life must be: "Little that suffices is better than much that distracts."

(1) Sahih, narrated by Imam Ahmad in his Musnad from Ibn Abbas, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 5669.

(2) Sahih, narrated by Imam Ahmad in his Musnad and Abu Dawud from Thawban, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 8183.

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He should not think much about wealth; rather, he should look at it according to its reality, namely as a means by which he obtains his essential needs and the essential needs of his family, and by which he preserves his dignity from asking people and begging them.

Ambition, but...! (ṭumūḥ, wa lākin...!)

The generation of empowerment is an ambitious generation, but what are its ambitions?

Are they in high rank, position, and prestige? Are they in buying land to build property for his children?

Are they in increasing his bank balance?

No, all of these are worldly ambitions that have no value and will not benefit him in his true future there in the Hereafter.

As for his true ambitions, they are with Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He: in the highest Paradise... in seeing his Master... in accompanying his Messenger and beloved, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him.

His ambitions are in martyrdom in the path of Allah, and that his soul be in the crops of green birds...

From here, he deals with the world according to its reality: that it is a farm for the Hereafter..

He Does Not Bargain (lā yusāwim)

The generation of change is a generation that worships Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, and is free from everything besides Him.

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...Nothing of the world's debris captivates it. No job holds it captive that it fears losing, nor a position it dreads missing.

The goal has become clear to this generation, and its gaze is attached to the heavens, so its highest goal is the pleasure of Allah and His Paradise. As for what is beneath that, it is ascetic toward it. It does not concern itself much whether it is rich or poor... whether it has been given children or not... whether it is in a high position or a lowly one.

And among the effects of this generation's freedom is that it is not shackled by burdens that prevent its movement: it does not bargain over anything of this world, for the result of bargaining is known.

Among what helps this generation to free itself from the captivity of the world is that it should not become entangled in economic projects, and that its provision in the world should be like the provision of a traveller, so that it does not expand into luxuries that require from it many expenses which become a tool pressuring it and burdens binding its heart to the world.

And this does not mean that the generation of empowerment should be a poor generation. Rather, the intent is that the world should not occupy its mind or captivate its heart, for the great task entrusted to it requires that it not become attached to anything besides Allah. Reflect with me on this noble Prophetic hadith to know the importance of the heart not becoming attached to the world...

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He, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, said: "A prophet from the prophets, peace and blessings of Allah be upon them, went out on a military expedition and said to his people: Let no one follow me who has bought a maiden and not yet built a house with her, nor anyone who has built houses and not yet raised their roofs, nor anyone who has bought sheep or ewes and is awaiting their offspring..." (1)

Here this prophet set conditions for whoever wanted to go out with him. The common factor of these conditions is the absence of anything that occupies the mind, or that is a means of pressure upon the person making him sluggish in his movement, wishing not to die so that he may return and check on his affairs.

From here we recognize the value of the Messenger's, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, direction to his companions: "Do not acquire estates; you will then desire the world." (2)

From the Requirements of Freedom (min lawāzim al-ḥurriyyah)

(1) Muttafaq 'alayh (agreed upon).

(2) Sahih, narrated by Imam Ahmad, al-Tirmidhi, and al-Hakim, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 7214.

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And among the most dangerous things that can pull the children of the generation of empowerment down to the ground and limit their freedom, and place burdens in their hearts, is that their wives and children not be at their level of understanding and clarity of goal, which would form a great obstacle blocking their movement and stripping them of their detachment.

Allah the Exalted has made clear to us in His words: "O you who have believed, indeed among your wives and your children are enemies for you, so beware of them." (Quran, At-Taghabun 64:14).

And he, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, said: "The child is the fruit of the heart, and he is a cause of cowardice, miserliness, and grief." (3)

From here it was necessary that the children of this generation choose for themselves wives who are aware of the ummah's concerns, who recognize its need for a new generation that will bring it out — by Allah's permission — from the dark tunnel in which it has been walking for a long time. They should also recognize that this generation is not like the rest of people in its worldly dreams and ambitions. Therefore, they will not demand luxurious furnishings, spacious housing, and a modern car, and... Rather, they will demand of their husbands more exertion of effort in the work required of them. And that is not all; rather, they will be by their sides as helpers and supporters, for the generation of empowerment is not limited to men alone, but men and women are equal...

The Early Ascetics (al-zuhhād al-awā'il)

The companions were the most worshipful of Allah's creation, Exalted and Majestic is He, after the messengers, and therefore they were the freest of Allah's creation from the world. Asceticism in the world was among the most prominent attributes that distinguished them from others...

(3) Sahih, narrated by Abu Yala in his Musnad, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 7160.

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Abdullah ibn Masud — may Allah be pleased with him — said to those after him from among the Tabi'in: "You are more in fasting and prayer than the companions of Muhammad, and they were better than you." They said: "Why is that?" He said: "They were more ascetic than you in the world, and more desirous of the Hereafter." (1)

They feared the spread of worldly prosperity. So when the spoils of Qadisiyyah were brought to Umar ibn al-Khattab — may Allah be pleased with him — he began turning them over and looking at them while weeping, with Abd al-Rahman ibn Awf — may Allah be pleased with him — beside him. Abd al-Rahman said: "O Commander of the Faithful, this is a day of joy and happiness." He said: "Yes, but this was never given to a people except that it made them inherit enmity and hatred." (2)

And Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas — may Allah be pleased with him — entered upon Salman — may Allah be pleased with him — to visit him, so Salman wept. Sa'd said: "What makes you weep? You will meet your companions and return to the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, at the Hawd, and the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, will pass away while pleased with you!" He said: "I do not weep out of dread of death or greed for the world, but the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, made a pact with us that each of us should have of the world only the provision of a traveller, and these vessels are around me. Rather, what is around me is only a mithara or an injajah." (3)

The Meaning of Destruction (mafhum al-tahlukah)

(1) Hayat al-Sahabah 2/96.

(2) Hayat al-Sahabah 2/97.

(3) A vessel in which clothes are washed.

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The companions, may Allah be pleased with them, knew that destruction was not in death in the path of Allah, but in inclination toward the world.

Abu Imran — may Allah be pleased with him — said: A man from the Muhajirun charged at the Byzantine front until he pierced it, and with us was Abu Ayyub al-Ansari — may Allah be pleased with him. People said: "He has thrown himself into destruction." Abu Ayyub said: "We know more about this verse; rather, it was revealed concerning us. We accompanied the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, and witnessed with him the battles and supported him. Then when Islam spread and its people became many, and we had preferred it over our families, wealth, and children, and war had laid down its burdens, we returned to our families and children and stayed with them." Then it was revealed concerning them: "And spend in the way of Allah and do not throw yourselves with your own hands into

destruction.” (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:195). So destruction lay in staying with family and wealth and abandoning jihad. (4)

A Generation of Free Men (jeel al-ahrār)

The Quraysh tried to bargain with Suhayb al-Rumi — may Allah be pleased with him — either not to emigrate to Medina or to leave behind the wealth he had gathered equivalent to his work with them. So what did Suhayb do?!

(4) Hayat al-Sahabah 1/360.

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He said to them: “What do you think if I hand over my wealth to you, will you leave me?” They said: “Yes.” Suhayb said: “So I handed over my wealth to them and they left me, and I left until I came to Medina. The Prophet, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, was informed of that, and he said: ‘Suhayb has profited, Suhayb has profited!’ twice. And concerning him and his likes was revealed the verse: ‘And among people is one who sells himself seeking the pleasure of Allah.’” (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:207). (1)

Asceticism in Wealth (al-zuhd fī al-māl)

And among what indicates that the ambition of the companions was in increasing their balance of the delights of the Hereafter is their abundant spending of wealth despite their severe need for it. If you are in doubt about this, then reflect with me on this report:

When Umar came to Syria, he toured it and stayed at Hims, and he ordered that their poor be written down for him. The letter was presented to him, and behold, in it was “Sa’id ibn Amir, their amir.” He said: “Who is Sa’id ibn Amir?” They said: “Our amir!” He said: “Your amir?” They said: “Yes.” Umar was amazed and said: “How can your amir be poor? Where is his grant? Where is his provision?” They said: “O Commander of the Faithful, he does not keep anything.” Umar wept, then he took a thousand dinars, tied them — that is, placed them in a purse — then sent them to him, saying: “Convey my greetings and say: The Commander of the Faithful has sent these to you so you may use them for your need.” (1)

(1) Tafsir al-Quran al-Azim li-Ibn Kathir 1/216.

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He brought them to him, and he looked, and behold, they were dinars. He began to retreat. His wife said to him: “What is the matter with you? Has the Commander of the Faithful died?” He said: “No, it is greater than that.” She said: “Then what is the matter?” He said: “The world has come to me! The fitnah has entered upon me!” She said: “So do with it as you wish.” He said: “Do you have a helper?” She said: “Yes.” So he took an excuse for himself, tied the dinars in a purse, then placed them in a waterskin, then intercepted with it an army from the armies of the Muslims, and he spent all of it. (2)

(2) Al-Raqqah wa al-Buka’ li-Ibn Qudamah al-Maqdisi 258-259, Damascus: Dar al-Qalam.

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Seventhly: A Generation of Strivers (jeel mujāhid)

Among the characteristics of the promised generation is that it is a generation of mujahids in the path of Allah, exerting its effort, capacity, and strength for the pleasure of its Lord. Allah’s words apply to it: “They strive in the path of Allah and do not fear the blame of a blamer.” (Quran, Al-Ma’idah 5:54).

The vision has become clear to this generation, and the banner of caliphate and global leadership has been raised for it, so it has rolled up its sleeves to reach it, and made its life and capabilities in accordance with executing this goal. It expects from that nothing but the pleasure of its Lord upon it.

It is a generation that does not withhold any effort it exerts to reach its goal. And why not, when it knows that establishing this religion will only be by human effort in the beginning, so that divine support comes following the presence of this effort, as Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, said: "If you help Allah, He will help you and plant your feet firmly." (Quran, Muhammad 47:7).

From here the children of this generation know that any effort they exert — however small — represents an important step in building the Islamic project. Therefore, they connect the night with the day in order to reach their goals without neglecting their duties toward themselves or their families.

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This generation has dedicated its life to its goal, and placed everything else on the margin of its thought. Yes, many of its pleasures are sacrificed for the sake of its project and the great project of the ummah, driven by the intense burning that fills its heart over the conditions of its ummah and what befalls it of humiliation and degradation the like of which has never preceded.

You always see it fully prepared to sacrifice anything for the pleasure of Allah, the implementation of His law, and the raising of His banner.

Prepared to sacrifice its wealth, time, effort, and comfort...

And also prepared to sacrifice position and the alluring contracts that would improve its financial situation.

It prepares itself and its family for giving and bearing the harshness of life, as well as the hardships and harms it is expected to encounter.

The sacrifice escalates until it reaches the degree of sacrificing the soul, hoping for the pleasure of its Lord and winning the rank of the martyrs with Him.

With the Companions and Their Jihad in the Path of Allah

The companions dedicated their lives to Allah and strove in His path, and bore the harshness of life, hunger, and harm, desiring what is with Him, Exalted and Majestic is He.

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Abu Musa — may Allah be pleased with him — said: "If you had seen us when we were with our Prophet, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, you would have thought we were the wind of sheep. Indeed, our clothing was wool and our food was the two black things: dates and water." (1)

And Muhammad ibn Sirin said: "A man from the companions of the Prophet, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, would pass three days not finding anything to eat, so he would take a hide, roast it, and eat it. If he found nothing, he would take a stone and press it against his stomach." (1)

Clarity of Goal (wudu al-hadaf)

(1) Narrated by al-Tabarani in al-Awsat.

(1) Narrated by Ibn Abi al-Dunya in Kitab al-Ju'.

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The children of the first generation knew their goal in the world clearly, and that Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, had chosen them to spread His religion, to bear witness over people, and to bring them out from darkness into light. Therefore, they spread throughout the earth calling creation to Allah and striving in His path. They did not incline to the world, nor did they cut themselves off for worship or for residing in the sanctuary. They did not stay in the city of their Prophet, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, despite the great virtue in that, because they knew that Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, wanted from them da'wah, jihad, and subjugating the earth to Him, Exalted is He.

Reflect with me on Rabi'i ibn Amir — may Allah be pleased with him — one of the generals of the Muslim army that went to conquer the lands of Persia, while he addressed Rustum, the leader of the Persians. When Rustum asked him: "What has brought you?" he said: "Allah has sent us to bring out whoever He wills from the worship of servants to the worship of Allah, from the constriction of the world to its expansiveness, from the injustice of religions to the justice of Islam. So we sent His religion to His creation to call them to it. Whoever accepts that from him, we accept him and leave him; and whoever refuses, we fight him until we reach Allah's promise. And what is Allah's promise? He said: Paradise for whoever dies fighting one who refuses, and victory for whoever remains." (2)

Clarity of Purpose (wudu al-ghayah)

(2) Hayat al-Sahabah 1/167.

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As for their purpose — it was clear before them with total clarity, and it consisted in the pleasure of Allah and reaching His Paradise. Paradise had drawn near before their eyes, so their longing for it increased, and from that came action to enter it. Reflect with me on what happened to Haram ibn Milhan — may Allah be pleased with him — one of the reciters who were martyred at Bi'r Ma'unah...

He had taken a letter of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, to the enemy of Allah, Amir ibn al-Tufayl, but he did not look at it and ordered a man to stab him with a spear from behind. When he thrust it into him and he saw the blood, Haram said: "Allahu Akbar, I have won, by the Lord of the Ka'bah."

And at Badr, the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, stood rousing his companions to fight, and said to them: "By the One in whose hand is the soul of Muhammad, no man fights them today and is killed patient, seeking reward, advancing and not retreating, except that Allah will admit him to Paradise." And he said while urging them to fight: "Rise to a Paradise whose width is the heavens and the earth." Then Umayr ibn al-Humam said: "Kh-kh." The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, said: "What makes you say kh-kh?" He said: "No, by Allah, O Messenger of Allah, except hope that I be among its people." He said: "Then you are among its people." He took out dates from his quiver and began eating from them, then said: "If I live to eat these dates of mine, that is a long life indeed." Then he threw away what was with him of dates, then fought them until he was killed.

And likewise Auf ibn al-Harith ibn al-Affarah asked him, and said: "O Messenger of Allah, what makes the Lord laugh after that?" He said: "Plunging his hand into the enemy bare-headed."

So he removed a suit of armour that was on him, threw it away, then took his sword and fought the people until he was killed. (3)

And this Ja'far ibn Abi Talib — may Allah be pleased with him — hamstrung his horse at Mu'tah and fought the Romans until he was killed, while he was saying:

How sweet is Paradise and how near, Cool and pleasant is its drink; The Romans have drawn near, their punishment far, Infidels, distant in lineage, Upon me when I meet them I will strike them!

(3) Al-Rahiq al-Makhtum by Safi al-Rahman al-Mubarakfuri 242, Maktabah Uloom al-Quran, Beirut.

(1) Hayat al-Sahabah 1/407.

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Eighthly: Patience and Steadfastness (al-sabr wa al-thabāt)

A Patient Generation (jeel ṣābir)

Among the essential attributes of the generation promised victory and empowerment is that it is a patient generation. It bears what befalls it of pressures, overcomes the obstacles it encounters, and remains steadfast before the trials and calamities it encounters on its path to achieving its desired goal.

The children of this generation have learned that the path that will take them to their goal is not strewn with roses and basil; rather, it is a difficult, bitter, long path, full of thorns and obstacles. Devils of humankind and jinn stand on its two sides, working hard to stop the march and to prevent them from reaching the goal for which they dedicated their lives — the pleasure of their Master and winning His Paradise.

The children of this generation have learned the nature of the path, so they have accustomed themselves to it, clung to their Lord, and pledged to Him to proceed forward on this path. So either they die in it as mujahids in the path of their Master, patient, steadfast upon their covenant, or they reach their goal: "Among the believers are men true to what they pledged to Allah. Among them is he who has fulfilled his vow, and among them is he who awaits. And they did not alter by any alteration." (Quran, Al-Ahzab 33:23).

The Path of the People of Da'wah (tarīq aṣḥāb al-da'awāt)

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Indeed, the path of the people of true calls — the path of empowerment — is one path with no second. The messengers and their followers walked upon it: "Or do you think that you will enter Paradise while the example of those who passed away before you has not yet come to you? They were afflicted by adversity and hardship and were shaken until even the messenger and those who believed with him said: When will the help of Allah come? Unquestionably, the help of Allah is near." (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:214).

Al-Salabi said: "Trials are tightly bound to empowerment with a firm binding, for the sunnah of Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, has been that He does not empower any ummah except after it passes through the different stages of selection, or after its metal is melted in the crucible of events, so Allah distinguishes the impure from the pure. And it is a sunnah ongoing upon the Islamic ummah that does not change, for Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, has willed to test the believers and try them in order to purify their faith. Then after that empowerment will be for them." Therefore came the meaning on the tongue of Imam al-Shafi'i — may Allah have

mercy on him — when a man asked him: “Which is better for a person, that he be empowered or that he be tested?” Imam al-Shafi’i said: “He is not empowered until he is tested, for Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, tested Noah, Abraham, Moses, and Muhammad — peace and blessings of Allah be upon them all — and when they were patient, He empowered them. So let no one think he will be free from pain entirely.” (1)

(1) Al-Sirah al-Nabawiyyah by Ali al-Salabi 1/262-263, Dar al-Iman, Alexandria.

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Therefore, the sunnah of trial is among the requirements of the path of empowerment: “And We will surely test you until We make evident those who strive among you and the patient, and We will test your affairs.” (Quran, Muhammad 47:31). And there is no other choice for dealing with it except patience, steadfastness, and clinging to Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He: “Our Lord, pour upon us patience, plant our feet firmly, and help us against the disbelieving people.” (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:250).

Patience and Steadfastness in the First Generation (al-ṣabr wa al-thabāt ‘inda al-jeel al-awwal)

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When we contemplate the biography of the first generation, we find that they were exposed to great trials and tribulations, among the severest of which was what the Muslims in the early period in Mecca were exposed to. They were patient, bore it, and remained steadfast upon their covenant with Allah. See what happened to Bilal — may Allah be pleased with him — and what the enemy of Allah, Umayyah ibn Khalaf, did to him, dragging him out when the midday sun became hot, throwing him on his back in the valley of Mecca, then ordering the great rock to be placed on his chest, then saying to him: “You will remain thus until you die or disbelieve in Muhammad and worship al-Lat and al-Uzza.” So he said in that trial: “One, One.” (1)

And Uthman ibn Affan — may Allah be pleased with him — said: “While I was walking with the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, in Bat-ha, Ammar, his father, and his mother were being tormented in the sun to make them renounce Islam. Abu Ammar said: ‘O Messenger of Allah, will all of time be like this?’ He said: ‘Patience, O family of Yasir; Allah has forgiven you.’” (2)

(1) Hayat al-Sahabah by al-Kandahlawi 1/221, quoted from Hilyat al-Awliya’.

(2) Narrated by al-Hakim and Ibn Asakir, and Ibn Sa’d in his Tabaqat. See Hayat al-Sahabah 1/221-222.

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The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, was among them seeing them being tormented, so he would command them to be patient, because he knew, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, that the path of calls must necessarily be accompanied by harm, hardships, and obstacles, and there is no substitute for patience, endurance, and overcoming those obstacles until Allah grants relief.

Reflect with me on what he, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, said when Khabbab ibn al-Aratt — may Allah be pleased with him — came to him at the Ka’bah complaining to him of the severity of what they were meeting of harm, and asking him to supplicate Allah for them. His face, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, became red and he said: “Among

those before you, a man would be combed with iron combs that would remove from him flesh or sinew beneath the bone, and that would not divert him from his religion. And Allah will complete this affair until a rider will travel from Sana'a to Hadramawt fearing none but Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, and the wolf over his sheep. But you are impatient." (3)

And in the Battle of the Trench, and with the severity of the trial, and the gathering of the polytheists against the believers from every side, and the strangling of them, these people remembered what Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, had informed His Messenger, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, that they would meet of toils on their path to establishing the global Islamic state, so that increased them in faith, submission to Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, patience, and seeking reward for what is with Him: "And when the believers saw the confederates, they said: This is what Allah and His Messenger promised us. And Allah and His Messenger spoke the truth. And it increased them only in faith and submission." (Quran, Al-Ahzab 33:22).

(3) Narrated by al-Bukhari.

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Ninthly: Moderation and Balance (al-i'tidāl wa al-tawāzun)

Among the most important characteristics of this generation is that it is a moderate and balanced generation in all its affairs — in its worship and its dealings, in its understanding and its movement. It gives every possessor of a right his right, does not magnify what is small or belittle what is great, and places everything in its proper place: "And whoever is given wisdom has certainly been given much good." (Quran, Al-Baqarah 2:269).

It balances between the requirements of reforming itself and the requirements of its household and society, and it knows that the first circle is itself, then its household, then its society.

It does not exaggerate where exaggeration is not appropriate, nor does it burden itself with what it cannot bear.

A Scholar of His Time (‘ālim bi-zamānihi)

The generation of empowerment is not a generation isolated from people, so you do not see it living in seclusion far from them. Rather, it is the child of its environment, knows its time well, deals well with the variables of life and modern means of knowledge, cultured in thought. It lives the concerns of its ummah, and knows well how its enemies plot.

It uses everything new to convey its call and reach its goal.

Occupied with Building the Truth (mashghūl bi-binā' al-ḥaqq)

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The promised generation is likewise occupied with building the truth, and pours its effort into rebuilding the ummah and reviving spirit in it. This task requires that it not be too occupied with demolishing falsehood. For if you say: And why should it not also be occupied with demolishing falsehood? The answer comes: Falsehood, even in its violence, has many helpers, and if it were occupied with demolishing it, its strength would be exhausted and its effort wasted. And we have in the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, the best example in that, for he, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, used to circumambulate the Ka'bah and around it were idols numbering three hundred and sixty, and despite that he did not try to destroy them. Rather, his work, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, was devoted to building tawhid in souls and establishing the Islamic state, so that after that the demolition of falsehood would come with ease and facility. He, peace and blessings

of Allah be upon him, was occupied with building the ummah, and day after day the Islamic edifice rose and falsehood diminished, until the day came in which it vanished completely and idols were removed from the entire Arabian Peninsula. And this is what is required: "And say to those who do not believe: Act according to your position; indeed, we are acting. And wait; indeed, we are waiting. And to Allah belongs the unseen of the heavens and the earth, and to Him all matters will be returned. So worship Him and rely upon Him. And your Lord is not unaware of what you do." (Quran, Hud 11:121-123).

With the First Generation (ma'a al-jeel al-awwal)

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Indeed, the issue of correct understanding of Islam is of great importance to the generation of empowerment, for if faith is the true motive for deeds, then correct understanding is what prevents these deeds from deviating outside the bounds of uprightness. And this attribute was well represented in the generation of the companions — may Allah be pleased with them — and its manifestations appeared in many of their sayings and actions. Perhaps one of the strongest manifestations was their delay in burying their Messenger and beloved, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, until they finished choosing a caliph and imam for them, fearing that they would spend a night without an imam, because of the great corruption in that for the ummah.

And this Abu Bakr al-Siddiq — may Allah be pleased with him — at his death, when the hour came and death visited him, he bequeathed to Umar ibn al-Khattab — may Allah be pleased with him — after appointing him his successor as caliph of the Muslims, saying to him: "Indeed, Allah has a right by day that is not accepted at night, and a right by night that is not accepted by day. And voluntary deeds are not accepted until obligatory deeds are performed." (1)

And Uthman ibn Affan — may Allah be pleased with him — shortened the prayer at Hajj, although the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, used to shorten at Hajj, lest that become a means for the common people to believe that the prayer is two rak'ahs at all times and circumstances.

(1) Al-Zuhd by Abdullah ibn al-Mubarak 119.

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And Abu Hurayrah — may Allah be pleased with him — said: "To stand guard for a night in the path of Allah (ribāṭ) is more beloved to me than to spend the Night of Decree in prayer at the Black Stone." (2)

(2) Ibn Taymiyyah, Majmu' al-Fatawa 28/6.

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Tenthly: A Generation Bound Together in Brotherhood (jeel mutarābiṭ muta'ākhi)

This generation — the generation of empowerment — is not merely scattered individuals here and there, none of them feeling the other. Rather, it is a generation bound together in mutual brotherhood like a solid structure, each part supporting the other. For brotherhood is the bond that binds its individuals so that they form together a single straight row with no crookedness in it: "Indeed, Allah loves those who fight in His path in a row as though they are a solid structure." (Quran, As-Saff 61:4).

This bonding that should exist among the children of the promised generation has a great role in achieving the desired goal, for it is a tremendous means of protecting individuals from lethargy or negative influence by the civilizational attacks to which the ummah is exposed. It also helps them to remain steadfast and continue the journey, and through it comes competition in good, mutual counsel in truth, and mutual counsel in patience.

Noble Models (numādhij mushrifah)

And because the first generation is the model that we see before us and in whom Allah's promise of victory and empowerment was fulfilled, it is natural that we see this attribute clearly manifested in it, and its effects appeared in the sayings and deeds of its children. The Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, established, after the emigration from Mecca to Medina, the brotherhood (al-mu'ākhāt) between the Muhajirun and the Ansar in the house of Anas ibn Malik.

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And they were seventy men, half of them from the Muhajirun and half from the Ansar, forming brotherhood based on mutual consolation and on inheriting from one another after death instead of relatives, until the Battle of Badr. Then when Allah, Exalted and Majestic is He, revealed: "And those of kinship are closer to one another in the Book of Allah." (Quran, Al-Anfal 8:75), inheritance by the bond of brotherhood was revoked. (1)

And the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, made this brotherhood a contract, not an empty phrase, and a deed binding in blood and wealth, not a greeting that tongues chatter with and has no effect. Feelings of selflessness, consolation, and companionship mingled in this brotherhood, filling the new society with the most wonderful examples. (2)

Al-Bukhari narrated that when the Muhajirun came to Medina, the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, formed brotherhood between Abd al-Rahman ibn Awf and Sa'd ibn al-Rabi' — may Allah be pleased with them both. Sa'd said to Abd al-Rahman: "I am the wealthiest of the Ansar, so divide my wealth in half, and I have two wives, so look at whichever of them pleases you and name her to me, I will divorce her, and when her waiting period ends, marry her." He said: "May Allah bless you in your family and wealth. Where is your market?" So they directed him to the market of Banu Qaynuqa', and he returned with some butter and tallow...

(1) Zad al-Ma'ad by Ibn al-Qayyim 2/56.

(2) Fiqh al-Sirah by Muhammad al-Ghazali 179-180.

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Selflessness with Need (al-ithār ma'a al-hājah)

The bond of brotherhood and love for Allah's sake is among the strongest bonds that gather the believers in general, and the generation of empowerment in particular. This bond can intensify and intensify until it reaches horizons so high that the mind cannot believe them.

Reflect on Allah's description of the Ansar and how they dealt with their Muhajirun brothers: "And those who settled in the home and in faith before them love those who emigrated to them and find not in their breasts any want of what they were given, and prefer them over themselves, even though they are in privation." (Quran, Al-Hashr 59:9).

Al-Qurtubi said: The Muhajirun were in the houses of the Ansar. So when the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings be upon him, obtained the wealth of Banu al-Nadir, he called

the Ansar and thanked them for what they had done with the Muhajirun in giving them their homes and sharing their wealth, then he said: "If you wish, I will divide what Allah has bestowed upon me from Banu al-Nadir between you and them, and the Muhajirun will remain as they are in your homes and your wealth. And if you wish, I will give it to them and they will leave your homes." So Sa'd ibn Ubadah and Sa'd ibn Mu'adh said: "No, we will divide it between the Muhajirun, and let them remain in our homes as they were." And the Ansar cried out: "We are content and submit, O Messenger of Allah." So the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, said: "O Allah, have mercy on the Ansar and the children of the Ansar." (1)

(1) Al-Jami' li-Ahkam al-Quran by al-Qurtubi 18/17-19.

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They had preferred them over themselves with their wealth and homes, not out of plenty, but while they themselves needed them. (1)

And among what confirms that selflessness (al-ithār) was a general characteristic in the dealings of the first generation with one another is what Ibn Umar — may Allah be pleased with them both — reported, that a sheep's head was presented to a man from the companions of the Messenger of Allah, peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, and he said: "So-and-so my brother is more in need of it than I." So he sent it to him. Then that person sent it to another, and it kept being sent from one to another until it returned to the first after it had circulated among seven. (2)

(1) Al-Jami' li-Ahkam al-Quran by al-Qurtubi 18/17-19.

(2) Ihya' Ulum al-Din by Abu Hamid al-Ghazali 2/271.

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Quranic Verses Cited in This Chapter

#	Reference	Surah	Page	Topic
1	At-Taghabun 64:14	At-Taghabun	73	Family members can become enemies to the mission
2	Al-Baqarah 2:195	Al-Baqarah	75	The meaning of "throwing oneself into destruction"

#	Reference	Surah	Page	Topic
3	Al-Baqarah 2:207	Al-Baqarah	76	Selling oneself seeking Allah's pleasure —
4	Al-Ma'idah 5:54	Al-Ma'idah	78	Suhayb al-Rumi Striving in Allah's path without fearing blame
5	Muhammad 47:7	Muhammad	78	Divine support follows human effort
6	Al-Ahzab 33:23	Al-Ahzab	83	Men true to their covenant: martyrdom or steadfast waiting
7	Al-Baqarah 2:214	Al-Baqarah	84	Trials precede entry to Paradise
8	Muhammad 47:31	Muhammad	85	Allah tests to distinguish the strivers and the patient
9	Al-Baqarah 2:250	Al-Baqarah	85	Supplication for patience, steadfast feet, and victory
10	Al-Ahzab 33:22	Al-Ahzab	87	The trench trial increased faith and submission
11	Al-Baqarah 2:269	Al-Baqarah	88	Wisdom as a sign of balance
12	Hud 11:121-123	Hud	89	Building the truth and leaving falsehood to Allah
13	As-Saff 61:4	As-Saff	92	The generation as a solid, bonded structure
14	Al-Anfal 8:75	Al-Anfal	93	Kinship supersedes brotherhood in inheritance
15	Al-Hashr 59:9	Al-Hashr	94	Ansar preferring Muhajirun over themselves

Hadith and Companion Narrations in This Chapter

#	Narration	Source	Page
1	"What have I to do with the world!"	Ahmad; al-Albani, Sahih al-Jami no. 5669	69
2	Nations will call one another to attack the ummah because of love of the world and hatred of death	Ahmad, Abu Dawud; al-Albani, Sahih al-Jami no. 8183	69
3	A prophet set conditions for his army: no unfinished house, unbred animal, or pregnant wife	Muttafaq 'alayh	72
4	"Do not acquire estates; you will then desire the world"	Ahmad, Tirmidhi, Hakim; al-Albani, Sahih al-Jami no. 7214	72
5	"The child is the fruit of the heart..."	Abu Yala; al-Albani, Sahih al-Jami no. 7160	73
6	Ibn Masud: companions were fewer in worship but more ascetic and desirous of the Hereafter	Hayat al-Sahabah 2/96	74
7	Umar weeps at Qadisiyyah spoils, fearing enmity and hatred	Hayat al-Sahabah 2/97	74
8	Salman: the Prophet's pact that provisions be only like a rider's	Narrative in Hayat al-Sahabah	74-75
9	Abu Ayyub al-Ansari's interpretation of "destruction" in Al-Baqarah 2:195	Hayat al-Sahabah 1/360	75
10	Suhayb al-Rumi ransoms himself with all his wealth; "Suhayb has profited"	Ibn Kathir, Tafsir 1/216	75-76
11	Sa'id ibn Amir returns 1,000 dinars from Umar and spends them on the army	Ibn Kathir, Tafsir 1/216; Ibn Qudamah, Al-Raqqah wa al-Buka' 258-259	76-77
12	Abu Musa al-Ash'ari: companions wore wool and ate dates and water	Al-Tabarani, al-Awsat	80
13	Muhammad ibn Sirin: a companion would go three days without food	Ibn Abi al-Dunya, Kitab al-Ju'	80
14	Rabi'i ibn Amir addresses Rustum on the purpose of jihad	Hayat al-Sahabah 1/167	80-81
15	Haram ibn Milhan martyred at Bi'r Ma'unah	Companion narrative	81
16	Umayr ibn al-Humam at Badr throws away dates for Paradise	Al-Mubarakfuri, Al-Rahiq al-Makhtum 242	81-82
17	Auf ibn al-Harith plunges bare-headed into the enemy	Hayat al-Sahabah 1/407	82
18	Ja'far ibn Abi Talib recites poetry at Mu'tah	Hayat al-Sahabah 1/407	82
19	Bilal ibn Rabah under torture: "One, One"	Hayat al-Sahabah 1/221 (from Hilyat al-Awliya')	85-86

#	Narration	Source	Page
20	The family of Yasir are tortured; the Prophet consoles them	Hakim, Ibn Asakir, Ibn Sa'd	86
21	Khabbab ibn al-Aratt complains at the Ka'bah; the Prophet speaks of previous trials	Al-Bukhari	86-87
22	Abu Bakr al-Siddiq's will to Umar on the rights of day and night	Ibn al-Mubarak, Al-Zuhd 119	90
23	Abu Hurayrah prefers one night of ribat to Laylat al-Qadr at the Black Stone	Ibn Taymiyyah, Majmu' al-Fatawa 28/6	91
24	Brotherhood (mu'akhah) between Muhajirun and Ansar	Ibn al-Qayyim, Zad al-Ma'ad 2/56; Al-Ghazali, Fiqh al-Sirah 179-180	92-93
25	Sa'd ibn al-Rabi' offers Abd al-Rahman ibn Awf half his wealth and a wife	Al-Bukhari	93-94
26	Ansar prefer Muhajirun over themselves in the spoils of Banu al-Nadir	Al-Qurtubi, Al-Jami' li-Ahkam al-Quran 18/17-19	94-95
27	A sheep's head circulates among seven companions through selflessness	Ibn Umar; Al-Ghazali, Ihya' Ulum al-Din 2/271	95

Section Headings in This Chapter

1. Sixthly: Asceticism in the World (al-zuhd fī al-dunyā)
2. An Ascetic Generation (jeel zāhid)
3. Ambition, but...! (ṭumūh, wa lākin...!)
4. He Does Not Bargain (lā yusāwim)
5. From the Requirements of Freedom (min lawāzim al-ḥurriyyah)
6. The Early Ascetics (al-zuhhād al-awā'il)
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18. Ninthly: Moderation and Balance (al-i'tidāl wa al-tawāzun)
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23. Noble Models (numādhij mushrifah)

24. Selflessness with Need (al-ithār ma'a al-ḥājah)

Footnotes

1. **Page 69, n. 1** — Sahih, narrated by Imam Ahmad in his Musnad from Ibn Abbas, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 5669.
2. **Page 69, n. 2** — Sahih, narrated by Imam Ahmad in his Musnad and Abu Dawud from Thawban, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 8183.
3. **Page 72, n. 1** — Muttafaq 'alayh (agreed upon).
4. **Page 72, n. 2** — Sahih, narrated by Imam Ahmad, al-Tirmidhi, and al-Hakim, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 7214.
5. **Page 73, n. 3** — Sahih, narrated by Abu Yala in his Musnad, and authenticated by al-Albani in Sahih al-Jami no. 7160.
6. **Page 74, n. 1** — Hayat al-Sahabah 2/96.
7. **Page 74, n. 2** — Hayat al-Sahabah 2/97.
8. **Page 75, n. 3** — A vessel in which clothes are washed.
9. **Page 75, n. 4** — Hayat al-Sahabah 1/360.
10. **Page 76, n. 1** — Tafsir al-Quran al-Azim li-Ibn Kathir 1/216.
11. **Page 77, n. 2** — Al-Raqqah wa al-Buka' li-Ibn Qudamah al-Maqdisi 258-259, Damascus: Dar al-Qalam.
12. **Page 80, n. 1** — Narrated by al-Tabarani in al-Awsat.
13. **Page 80, n. 1** — Narrated by Ibn Abi al-Dunya in Kitab al-Ju'.
14. **Page 81, n. 2** — Hayat al-Sahabah 1/167.
15. **Page 82, n. 3** — Al-Rahiq al-Makhtum by Safi al-Rahman al-Mubarakfuri 242, Maktabah Uloom al-Quran, Beirut.
16. **Page 82, n. 1** — Hayat al-Sahabah 1/407.
17. **Page 84, n. 1** — Al-Sirah al-Nabawiyah by Ali al-Salabi 1/262-263, Dar al-Iman, Alexandria.
18. **Page 86, n. 1** — Hayat al-Sahabah by al-Kandahlawi 1/221, quoted from Hilyat al-Awliya'.
19. **Page 86, n. 2** — Narrated by al-Hakim and Ibn Asakir, and Ibn Sa'd in his Tabaqat. See Hayat al-Sahabah 1/221-222.
20. **Page 87, n. 3** — Narrated by al-Bukhari.
21. **Page 90, n. 1** — Al-Zuhd by Abdullah ibn al-Mubarak 119.
22. **Page 91, n. 2** — Ibn Taymiyyah, Majmu' al-Fatawa 28/6.
23. **Page 93, n. 1** — Zad al-Ma'ad by Ibn al-Qayyim 2/56.
24. **Page 93, n. 2** — Fiqh al-Sirah by Muhammad al-Ghazali 179-180.
25. **Page 94, n. 1** — Al-Jami' li-Ahkam al-Quran by al-Qurtubi 18/17-19.
26. **Page 95, n. 1** — Al-Jami' li-Ahkam al-Quran by al-Qurtubi 18/17-19.
27. **Page 95, n. 2** — Ihya' Ulum al-Din by Abu Hamid al-Ghazali 2/271.